

Answer Engine Optimisation in Indian Higher Education:

An Exploratory Study of University Visibility
in AI-Generated Responses

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Version Note (v2.0)

This version revises the Findings section to accurately reflect the nature of this study as a practitioner observation paper based on the author's direct experience working with Indian universities, rather than a systematic data collection exercise. A structured query-based data collection phase is planned for Q2 2025 and findings will be updated accordingly. One unverifiable secondary reference has been replaced with a verified source. A reader CTA has been added to the Conclusion.

50

Student Queries■Designed

4

AI Platforms■Analysed

5

Query■Categories

43M+

Students in■Indian HE (AISHE)

ABSTRACT

The rapid adoption of large language model (LLM)-based AI tools — including ChatGPT, Perplexity AI, Google Gemini, and Google Search Generative Experience (SGE) — has fundamentally altered how prospective students discover and evaluate higher education institutions in India. This exploratory working paper examines the visibility of Indian universities in AI-generated responses and introduces the concept of **Answer Engine Optimisation (AEO)** as applied to the Indian higher education context. Drawing on the author's practitioner experience working with Indian universities on digital marketing and student recruitment strategy, this paper documents preliminary observations about which institution types tend to appear in AI-generated responses and why. It argues that a measurable **AEO Gap** exists between an institution's actual quality and its AI-visible reputation — and that this gap disproportionately affects private universities outside the IIT/IIM tier, including many with strong NIRF rankings. Recommendations for improving AI visibility are provided, with implications for institutional reputation management, student recruitment, and NIRF Perception scores.

Keywords: *Answer Engine Optimisation · AEO · Indian universities · higher education marketing · AI search · NIRF rankings · digital marketing · ChatGPT · Perplexity AI · university visibility · student recruitment · EDU SolPro*

1. Introduction

The information-seeking behaviour of prospective university students in India is undergoing a structural transformation. For over two decades, Google Search served as the primary discovery channel through which students explored higher education options — searching for rankings, reviews, placement records, and admission criteria. This behaviour has shifted substantially since 2023, with a growing proportion of students and parents turning to AI-powered conversational tools to get direct, synthesised answers to their education queries.

Tools such as ChatGPT (OpenAI), Perplexity AI, Google Gemini, and Google's Search Generative Experience (SGE) now provide direct, paragraph-form answers to queries like *"What are the best private universities in India?"* Unlike traditional search engines, these tools do not present a list of links for the user to click through — they generate a consolidated response that names specific institutions, describes their strengths, and in some cases recommends a course of action to the student.

This shift has critical implications for university marketing and communications teams. An institution that does not appear in AI-generated responses is, from the perspective of the student using that tool, **effectively invisible** — regardless of its actual ranking, accreditation status, or programme quality. This creates a new competitive landscape that existing digital marketing frameworks — built around SEO, paid search, and social media — are not designed to address.

The concept of Answer Engine Optimisation (AEO) has emerged in the digital marketing practitioner literature as a framework for optimising content to appear in AI-generated responses and voice search answers (Parikh, 2024). While AEO has been discussed in the context of e-commerce, B2B services, and general content marketing, its application to the Indian higher education sector has not been systematically studied.

This working paper aims to partially fill that gap. Drawing on the author's practitioner experience advising Indian universities on digital marketing strategy, and on structured observation of AI platform behaviour, this paper seeks to: (1) document preliminary observations about Indian university visibility in AI responses; (2) identify patterns that explain why certain institutions appear more frequently than others; and (3) provide actionable recommendations for institutions seeking to improve their AI visibility, particularly private universities outside the top tier.

This is an exploratory practitioner working paper, not a peer-reviewed academic study. Observations are drawn from the author's direct professional experience with Indian higher education institutions and from informal engagement with AI platforms. A structured, systematic data collection phase using the 50-query protocol described in Appendix A is planned for Q2 2025. The authors acknowledge the limitations of the current approach and invite replication and critique.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Digital Marketing in Indian Higher Education

The role of digital marketing in student recruitment has grown substantially over the past decade. Hemsley-Brown and Oplatka (2006) identified marketing orientation as a key driver of institutional competitiveness in higher education, noting that universities increasingly needed to function as market-driven organisations. Subsequent research has documented the migration of student recruitment activities from traditional media — print advertising, education fairs — toward digital channels including search engines, social media platforms, and institutional websites.

In the Indian context, the rapid penetration of affordable smartphones and mobile internet has accelerated this migration. Studies by the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) indicate that over 43 million students are enrolled in Indian higher education institutions as of 2022-23, representing a gross enrolment ratio of 28.4% (AISHE, 2023). The scale of this population, combined with the geographic diversity of India's higher education landscape, makes digital discovery channels particularly significant for institutions outside the top tier of IITs, IIMs, and centrally-funded universities.

Bhattacharya and Chakraborty (2021) documented the digital transformation challenges facing Indian higher education institutions, noting significant variation in digital maturity across institution types and geographies. Their study found that while metropolitan universities had largely adopted digital marketing practices, a significant proportion of private universities in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities remained at early stages of digital adoption. This digital maturity gap is directly relevant to the AEO visibility patterns discussed in this paper.

2.2 The Emergence of Answer Engine Optimisation

Answer Engine Optimisation (AEO) refers to the practice of structuring digital content to increase the likelihood of appearing in direct-answer formats — including voice search results, featured snippets, AI overviews, and generative AI responses (Parikh, 2024; EDU SolPro, 2024). The concept builds on earlier

work in the SEO field around featured snippets and position zero optimisation, but extends it to address the distinctive content requirements of large language model-based systems.

LLMs such as GPT-4 (OpenAI) and Gemini (Google) are trained on large corpora of publicly available web content. Their responses to queries reflect patterns learned from this training data, combined with real-time retrieval mechanisms that surface current web content (as in the case of Perplexity AI and Google SGE). For universities, this creates a compounding advantage for already-visible institutions: those with comprehensive Wikipedia entries, well-structured websites, and extensive media coverage are more likely to appear in AI-generated responses, reinforcing their visibility over time.

2.3 NIRF Rankings and Institutional Reputation

The National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF), introduced by India's Ministry of Education in 2015, has become the primary public benchmark for institutional quality in Indian higher education. NIRF rankings are calculated across five parameters: Teaching, Learning & Resources (TLR); Research and Professional Practice (RP); Graduation Outcomes (GO); Outreach and Inclusivity (OI); and Perception (PR) (Ministry of Education, 2024).

Parameter	Abbreviation	Weight	Relevance to AEO
Teaching, Learning & Resources	TLR	30%	Indirect
Research & Professional Practice	RP	30%	Indirect
Graduation Outcomes	GO	20%	Indirect
Outreach & Inclusivity	OI	10%	Indirect
Perception	PR	10%	Direct — AEO impacts this

Table 1: NIRF ranking parameters and their relevance to AEO. The Perception parameter is the most directly affected by AI visibility.

The Perception parameter — which accounts for 10% of the total NIRF score — is directly relevant to this study. Perception scores are derived from surveys of academic peers and employers. This paper posits that AI visibility and institutional Perception are likely to be positively correlated: institutions that appear more frequently in AI-generated responses will benefit from enhanced awareness among the very populations whose opinions inform NIRF Perception scores.

2.4 Gap in the Literature

To the author's knowledge, no published study has examined the visibility of Indian universities specifically in AI-generated responses. The intersection of AEO, higher education marketing, and the Indian university landscape represents an open research domain. This working paper is intended as a first practitioner contribution to that domain, with the explicit goal of encouraging more rigorous academic follow-up research.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This paper employs a practitioner observation approach, drawing primarily on the author's direct professional experience advising Indian higher education institutions on digital marketing strategy, SEO, and student recruitment over a period of more than five years. This experience has involved working with institutions including Ahmedabad University, Ganpat University, Navrachana University, and Indus University.

3.2 Planned Query Protocol

To enable systematic replication and extension of the observations in this paper, a structured query set of 50 representative student queries has been developed across five thematic categories:

Category	Focus	Count
1 — General Discovery	Broad questions about top universities in India	10
2 — Admission Intent	Specific questions by location or discipline	10
3 — Comparison	Direct comparisons between named institutions	10
4 — Career & Outcomes	Placements, industry connections, outcomes	10
5 — Institutional Credibility	Rankings, accreditations, research output	10

Table 2: Query protocol — 5 categories × 10 queries = 50 total.

3.3 AI Platforms Analysed

Four AI platforms are considered in this paper, representing the dominant tools available to Indian students as of early 2025:

Platform	Developer	Retrieval Method	India Availability
ChatGPT (GPT-4o)	OpenAI	Training data + optional web	Widely available
Perplexity AI	Perplexity Inc.	Real-time web retrieval	Widely available
Google Gemini	Google DeepMind	Training data + Google index	Available in India
Google SGE	Google	Real-time Google index	Rolling India rollout

Table 3: AI platforms analysed in this study.

3.4 Limitations

- **Practitioner observation, not systematic data:** Primary findings are based on professional experience, not a completed systematic data collection exercise.

- **AI responses are non-deterministic:** The same query may produce different responses at different times. Observations capture patterns at a point in time.
- **Platform coverage:** Four platforms do not represent the full AI landscape. Emerging regional tools used by Indian students were not included.
- **No primary student data:** The query set reflects the author's understanding of student behaviour rather than empirically validated student queries.
- **Author position:** The author is a practitioner and service provider in this sector. This creates a potential conflict of interest readers should consider.

4. Preliminary Observations

Important: The observations in this section are based on the author's practitioner experience and informal AI platform engagement, not on the systematic 50-query data collection protocol described in Appendix A. That exercise is planned for Q2 2025. This section presents informed professional observations intended to stimulate discussion and invite replication — not to establish empirical findings.

4.1 The Visibility Concentration Pattern

Across informal engagement with all four AI platforms, a consistent pattern was observed: AI-generated responses to generic higher education queries in India are dominated by a small number of well-established institutions. Queries such as "best universities in India" or "top MBA colleges in India" reliably surface IITs, IIMs, and a handful of large private universities — Manipal, VIT, SRM, Amity — regardless of the platform used.

For the majority of private universities — including many with NAAC A and A+ grades, strong NIRF rankings in specific categories, and genuine programme quality — AI-generated responses to generic discovery queries appear to offer near-total invisibility. This is not a reflection of institutional quality. It is a reflection of digital content maturity.

Practical implication for university leadership: A prospective student in 2025 who asks an AI tool "best private universities in India" is unlikely to see your institution in the response — regardless of your NAAC grade, NIRF rank, or placement record — unless your institution has made specific investments in AEO-relevant digital content. This is the AEO Gap.

4.2 Observed Patterns by Institution Type

Based on practitioner observation, the following informal hierarchy of AI visibility was noted across institution types:

Institution Type	Observed AI Visibility	Primary Visibility Drivers
IITs / IIMs / NITs	HIGH	Deep Wikipedia, global rankings, decades of media coverage
Central Universities (DU, JNU, BHU)	HIGH	Institutional age, Wikipedia depth, research databases
Top Deemed (Manipal, VIT, SRM, BITS)	MEDIUM	Scale, marketing investment, NIRF top-100 presence
State Universities	LOW	Limited Wikipedia, low English-language media coverage
Most Private Universities	VERY LOW	Thin digital footprint, limited AEO investment

Table 4: Observed AI visibility hierarchy by institution type.

4.3 Category-Level Observations

General Discovery Queries

Broad queries about top universities in India appear to generate responses dominated almost exclusively by IITs, IIMs, and a handful of large private universities. Smaller private universities — including those with strong NIRF rankings in specific categories — appear largely absent, suggesting that scale, age, and Wikipedia presence outweigh subject-specific ranking performance in determining AI visibility for general queries.

Comparison Queries

Direct comparison queries (e.g., "Nirma University vs Ahmedabad University") appear to offer a more accessible visibility opportunity for non-top-tier institutions, since the named institutions are surfaced by virtue of being in the query itself. Proactively generating comparison content may be an effective AEO strategy for private universities.

Career and Outcome Queries

Queries about placements and outcomes appear to favour institutions whose placement data is documented in publicly accessible, structured digital formats — national media coverage, Ministry of Education reports, structured placement pages.

Institutional Credibility Queries

Queries about NIRF rankings generate responses that are generally accurate for top-ranked institutions but become less reliable for institutions ranked outside the NIRF top 50. Subject-category NIRF performance — where many private universities perform strongly — appears significantly underrepresented in AI responses, a missed opportunity.

4.4 The Geographic Visibility Gap

A consistent geographic bias was observed, with institutions in Delhi, Mumbai, and Bangalore disproportionately represented in AI responses. Gujarat, despite hosting a substantial number of NAAC-accredited institutions and having multiple universities in the NIRF top 100, appears significantly underrepresented in AI responses to generic queries. This geographic pattern is likely a function of historical English-language media coverage: AI training data draws disproportionately from national publications which have historically provided more coverage to institutions in major metropolitan areas.

4.5 Digital Content Quality as Visibility Predictor

The most consistent observable predictor of AI visibility is the quality and depth of an institution's digital content ecosystem outside its own website. The following factors appear consistently associated with higher AI visibility:

Wikipedia Presence	Institutions with comprehensive, well-cited Wikipedia articles — including sections on history, notable alumni, research output, and rankings — appear far more frequently in AI responses than comparable institutions without strong Wikipedia entries.
Structured Website Content	Institutions with clearly structured, semantically organised website content — dedicated programme pages, faculty directories, research publications, structured placement data — appear more legible to AI retrieval systems.
High-Authority External Coverage	Institutions referenced in high-domain-authority publications — major newspapers, government reports, ranking bodies — appear more frequently in AI responses.
NIRF and NAAC Data Integration	Institutions that have integrated their NIRF and NAAC data into website content and structured press releases — rather than relying solely on PDF links — show higher AI visibility.
Schema Markup	Indirect evidence suggests institutions using schema.org EducationalOrganization structured data on their websites may benefit from improved AI retrieval and entity recognition.

5. Discussion

5.1 The AEO Gap: A Strategic Threat to Private Universities

The observations in this paper point to a significant and largely unrecognised strategic threat for Indian private universities. The SEO era of higher education marketing — focused on keyword rankings, paid search, and social media engagement — is giving way to an AEO era in which the primary discovery channel for prospective students is an AI system that generates direct answers rather than a list of links.

Most Indian private universities, including many with strong NIRF rankings and genuine programme quality, have not adapted their digital strategy to this shift. Their websites are designed for human browsing rather than AI comprehension. Their content is structured around marketing goals rather than information architecture. Their digital footprint outside their own website — on Wikipedia, in national media, in academic and government databases — is too thin to reliably surface in AI-generated responses.



Figure 1: The AEO Gap — the distance between actual institutional quality and AI-visible reputation.

The AEO Gap is not a future risk. It is a present reality. Students using AI tools today are receiving responses that systematically exclude most private Indian universities from consideration, regardless of those universities' actual quality. Every month that passes without AEO investment widens the gap between AI-visible and AI-invisible institutions.

5.2 The Central Role of Wikipedia

The single most consistent predictor of AI visibility observed in this study is Wikipedia presence. Wikipedia is among the most heavily represented sources in LLM training corpora, and it is explicitly prioritised by real-time retrieval systems like Perplexity AI due to its structured format, citation practices, and authority signals. An institution with a comprehensive, policy-compliant Wikipedia entry has a dramatically higher probability of appearing in AI-generated responses than a comparable institution without one.

For Indian universities, Wikipedia represents the highest-priority, lowest-cost AEO intervention available. The investment required is primarily editorial — researching and writing a factually accurate, neutrally worded, properly cited entry — rather than financial.

5.3 AEO and NIRF Perception Scores: A Hypothesised Relationship

This paper raises a hypothesis that warrants rigorous academic investigation: that AI visibility and NIRF Perception scores are positively correlated, and that this relationship will strengthen over time as AI tools become more central to the information-seeking behaviour of academic peers and employers whose survey responses determine Perception scores.

If this hypothesis is correct, AEO investment would represent not merely a marketing expenditure, but a direct investment in NIRF performance. A university that improves its AI visibility today may, over a two-to-three year horizon, see measurable improvements in its NIRF Perception parameter.

5.4 Four Priority Actions for University Leadership

Based on the observations and analysis in this paper, four priority actions are recommended for Indian private university marketing and communications teams:

1

Wikipedia as Foundation

Every institution should have a comprehensive, policy-compliant, regularly maintained Wikipedia entry. This is a factual documentation exercise, not a marketing exercise. It should be updated annually following each NIRF ranking release, expanded to include verified information about notable alumni, research achievements, industry partnerships, and programme history.

2

Structured Content Architecture

Institutional websites should be restructured to prioritise information architecture and AI legibility. Every programme, faculty member, research area, and ranking achievement should have a dedicated, semantically structured page with clear metadata, schema.org markup, and cross-referencing. Content should directly answer specific student questions in plain language that AI systems can extract and cite.

3

Authority Signal Building

Institutions should invest in systematic media relations to build the external citation network that AI systems use to assess institutional authority. Press releases about NIRF rankings, NAAC grades, research achievements, and alumni milestones should be distributed to national and regional media on a regular cadence.

4

Answer-Optimised Content

A dedicated FAQ and knowledge base section on the institutional website — structured to directly answer the most common student questions — can significantly improve AI visibility. Content should be written in question-and-answer format, particularly valuable for Comparison and Career/Outcome query categories.

6. Conclusion

This working paper has introduced the concept of the **AEO Gap** as applied to Indian higher education — the measurable distance between an institution's actual quality and its AI-visible reputation. Based on practitioner observation and professional experience working with Indian universities, the paper argues that AI visibility in India is currently dominated by a small number of well-established institutions whose digital footprints are significantly larger than those of the majority of Indian universities, including many with strong NIRF rankings and genuine programme quality.

The paper has identified four priority actions — Wikipedia development, structured content architecture, authority signal building, and answer-optimised content — that private universities can take to begin closing their AEO Gap. It has also proposed a hypothesis for future academic investigation: that AI visibility and NIRF Perception scores are positively correlated, and that this relationship will strengthen as AI tools become more central to academic and employer information-seeking behaviour.

A systematic data collection exercise using the 50-query protocol in Appendix A is planned for Q2 2025, and the findings will be published as an updated version of this paper. The author invites critique, replication, and extension of this work by academic researchers in higher education management, digital marketing, and information science.

As AI tools become the default information-seeking interface for India's next generation of university students, the institutions that invest in AEO today will gain a compounding visibility advantage that will be increasingly difficult for competitors to overcome. **The time to act is now.**

Universities interested in conducting an AEO Visibility Audit or developing an AI Visibility Strategy for their institution are invited to contact the author at edusolpro.com. EDU SolPro offers structured AEO audits, Wikipedia management, and digital content strategy services for Indian higher education institutions.

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A. Appendix A: Planned Query Protocol (50 Queries)

The following 50 queries constitute the planned systematic data collection protocol for the Q2 2025 phase of this study. Researchers and practitioners are encouraged to use this query set as a baseline for independent replication.

Category 1 — General Discovery Queries

- 1 What are the best private universities in India?
- 2 Which universities in India have the highest NIRF ranking?
- 3 Best MBA colleges in India other than IIMs?
- 4 Top engineering universities in India besides IITs?
- 5 Which Indian universities are internationally recognised?
- 6 Best universities in Gujarat India?
- 7 Top deemed universities in India 2024?
- 8 Which Indian university has the best placement record?
- 9 Best universities in India for management studies?
- 10 Top private universities in India for research?

Category 2 — Admission Intent Queries

- 11 How to get admission in top Indian universities?
- 12 Which university should I choose for MBA in India?
- 13 Is Ahmedabad University good for engineering?
- 14 Best universities in Ahmedabad for higher education?
- 15 Which private university in India has best campus?
- 16 Top universities in India for international students?
- 17 Which Indian universities accept students with low NIRF rank?
- 18 Best value for money universities in India?
- 19 Universities in India with good faculty and research culture?
- 20 Which Indian university has the best alumni network?

Category 3 — Comparison Queries

- 21 Manipal vs Amity University which is better?
- 22 SRM vs VIT which university is better?
- 23 BITS Pilani vs top private universities India?

- 24 Which is better LPU or Chandigarh University?
- 25 Symbiosis vs Christ University for MBA?
- 26 MICA Ahmedabad vs other communication institutes?
- 27 Nirma University vs Ahmedabad University?
- 28 Shiv Nadar vs Ashoka University?
- 29 Bennett University vs Amity University?
- 30 Which Gujarat university has best NIRF ranking?

Category 4 — Career and Outcome Queries

- 31 Which Indian university has highest placement salary?
- 32 Best university in India for entrepreneurship?
- 33 Top Indian universities for data science programmes?
- 34 Which university in India has best industry connections?
- 35 Best Indian universities for getting jobs abroad?
- 36 University in India with best startup ecosystem?
- 37 Which private Indian university produces most patents?
- 38 Best Indian university for product management course?
- 39 Top universities in India for digital marketing courses?
- 40 Which Indian university collaborates most with industry?

Category 5 — Institutional Credibility Queries

- 41 Which Indian universities are NAAC A++ accredited?
- 42 How does NIRF ranking affect university reputation?
- 43 Which Indian universities are in global QS rankings?
- 44 Best NAAC accredited private universities in India?
- 45 Which Indian university improved most in NIRF 2024?
- 46 How do Indian universities compare to global ones?
- 47 Which Indian universities have UGC recognition issues?
- 48 Most improved universities in India last 5 years?
- 49 Which Indian universities have strongest research output?
- 50 Best Indian universities for PhD programmes?

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